

Week 6 Argument Lab

Good Form, Bad Facts

Name: _____

Date: _____

Purpose

This lab turns Week 6 reading into a portfolio artifact. You will diagnose arguments with two columns: a **form test** and a **fact test**. The goal is to stop using the word *valid* when you really mean *true*, *persuasive*, *likely*, or *morally attractive*.

Part I: Reference Box

Form test: Does the conclusion follow from the premises? **Fact test:** Are the premises true or adequately supported? **Sound argument:** valid form plus true premises. **Unsound argument:** invalid form or at least one false premise. **Not yet proved:** form may be valid, but a key premise remains doubtful or unsupported.

Part II: Model Diagnosis

Argument:

- All citizens who knowingly sell public secrets for private money betray their city.
- Marcus knowingly sold public secrets for private money.
- Therefore, Marcus betrayed his city.
- **Form test:** Valid. If both premises are true, the conclusion follows.
- **Fact test:** The second premise is the pressure point. Did Marcus knowingly sell secrets, and was it for private money?
- **Diagnosis:** The argument is sound only if that factual premise is proved. Until then, the conclusion is not yet proved.

Part III: Diagnose the Arguments

For each argument, complete both tests. Be precise: do not call an argument invalid merely because you doubt a premise.

1. Valid Form, False Premise

Argument: All birds can breathe underwater. All eagles are birds. Therefore, all eagles can breathe underwater.

Form test: Does the conclusion follow from the premises?

Fact test: Which premise is false or doubtful?

Final diagnosis: sound, unsound, or not yet proved?

2. True Conclusion, Bad Proof

Argument: All careful students own notebooks. Elena owns a notebook. Therefore, Elena is a careful student.

Form test: Does the conclusion follow from the premises?

Could the conclusion still be true? Why does that not make this proof good?

Final diagnosis:

3. Valid Form, Doubtful Premise

Argument: All speeches that intentionally deceive the people are unjust. This speech intentionally deceives the people. Therefore, this speech is unjust.

Form test:

Fact test: What would need to be proved about the speech?

Final diagnosis:

Part IV: Two-Column Argument Diagnosis

Choose one argument from Part III and fill out the diagnosis chart.

• **Conclusion:**

• **Form judgment:** valid or invalid?

• **Premise pressure point:**

- **Fact judgment:** true, false, doubtful, or not yet established?
- **What evidence would settle the fact test?**
- **Final diagnosis:**

Part V: Julius Caesar Application

Brutus's public argument can be reconstructed this way:

- All men whose ambition would enslave Rome deserve death for Rome's freedom.
- Caesar was a man whose ambition would enslave Rome.
- Therefore, Caesar deserved death for Rome's freedom.

Form test: Is this reconstruction valid? Explain.

Fact test: Which premise does Antony attack?

What evidence does Antony offer against that premise?

Does Antony prove Brutus wrong, or does he make Brutus's argument not yet proved? Explain carefully.

Part VI: Repair or Narrow

Choose one weak argument from this lab. Either strengthen a doubtful premise with evidence or narrow the conclusion so it no longer overclaims.

Original argument:

Problem: invalid form, false premise, doubtful premise, or overclaim?

Repaired or narrowed argument:

Part VII: Portfolio Artifact

Create a one-page **Form Test / Fact Test Diagnosis** for your Logic Portfolio. It should include:

1. a real or literary argument;
2. its conclusion;
3. a form judgment;
4. a fact judgment;
5. the premise pressure point;
6. a final diagnosis: sound, unsound, or not yet proved;
7. one sentence explaining why validity alone is not enough.

Portfolio summary starter: The argument's form is _____, but the premise that most needs testing is _____. This shows that validity is not enough because _____.